

Classic Chicago Magazine

Photo Standards

1. Overview

Photography is central to Classic Chicago Magazine. A strong hero image draws readers into an article; well-placed photos deepen the story. These standards ensure that photos look their best on the site and are published correctly.

Photos are handled collaboratively: writers send them, Judy reviews them editorially, and John and the production team place them on the site. Ana Baca handles photos for the About the Town column.

2. Technical Requirements

File Format

- JPEG (.jpg / .jpeg) is strongly preferred.
- PNG is acceptable for graphics or images without photographic content.
- Do not send images embedded in Word documents — attach them separately.

Resolution and File Size

- Minimum: 1,200 pixels on the longest side.
- Preferred: 2,000 pixels or wider for hero/cover images.
- File size: 300 KB–5 MB per image is ideal. Very small files may appear blurry.
- Color mode: RGB (not CMYK).

Orientation

- Landscape (horizontal) images work best for the hero/cover position.
- Portrait (vertical) images are fine for inline article photos.
- If a portrait photo is intended as the hero, let the editor know — cropping will be adjusted accordingly.

3. Sending Photos

How to Send

Attach photos directly to your submission email. Do not use file-sharing links unless the files are too large to attach — in that case, contact John first.

Naming Conventions

Use descriptive, lowercase filenames with hyphens instead of spaces:

jessie-mueller-cover.jpeg anti-cruelty-taffy.jpeg gala-crowd-wide.jpg

Avoid generic names like IMG_4872.jpg — these make it difficult to identify and place photos correctly.

Designating the Cover/Hero Photo

Every article needs one hero image. Designate it clearly:

- In your email subject line: "Cover photo for [Article Title]"
- Or in the email body: "[filename] is the cover photo."

If you don't designate one, the editor will choose the strongest image.

Number of Photos Per Article

- Standard articles: 2–5 photos (including hero).
- Event coverage: up to 8 photos if the event warrants it.
- Profiles and essays: 2–3 photos is usually sufficient.

More is not always better. Each photo should add something the text does not.

4. Captions

Every photo must have a caption. Captions provide context, credit photographers, and add another layer of storytelling.

Caption Format

Keep captions concise — one to two sentences. Describe what is happening in the photo, then credit the photographer if applicable:

Jessie Mueller in her Tony Award-winning role as Carole King in Beautiful. Photo: Matthew Murphy.

Where to Include Captions

- In the photo placement note in your article text: (Photo of Jessie Mueller as Carole King, caption: "Jessie Mueller in Beautiful. Photo: Matthew Murphy.")
- In your submission email, listing each filename with its caption.

5. Rights and Permissions

You are responsible for ensuring that photos you submit are cleared for publication.

- **Your own photos:** No additional permission needed.
- **Photos from subjects or publicists:** Written permission (email is fine) should be on file.
- **Third-party or stock photos:** Include the license or usage rights.
- **Photo credit:** Always credit the photographer. If from a press kit, credit as "Photo courtesy of [organization]."

Questions about photo submissions? Contact John Bartlett at john.bartlett@gmail.com.